

Living with Land and Forest

The Story of Podha



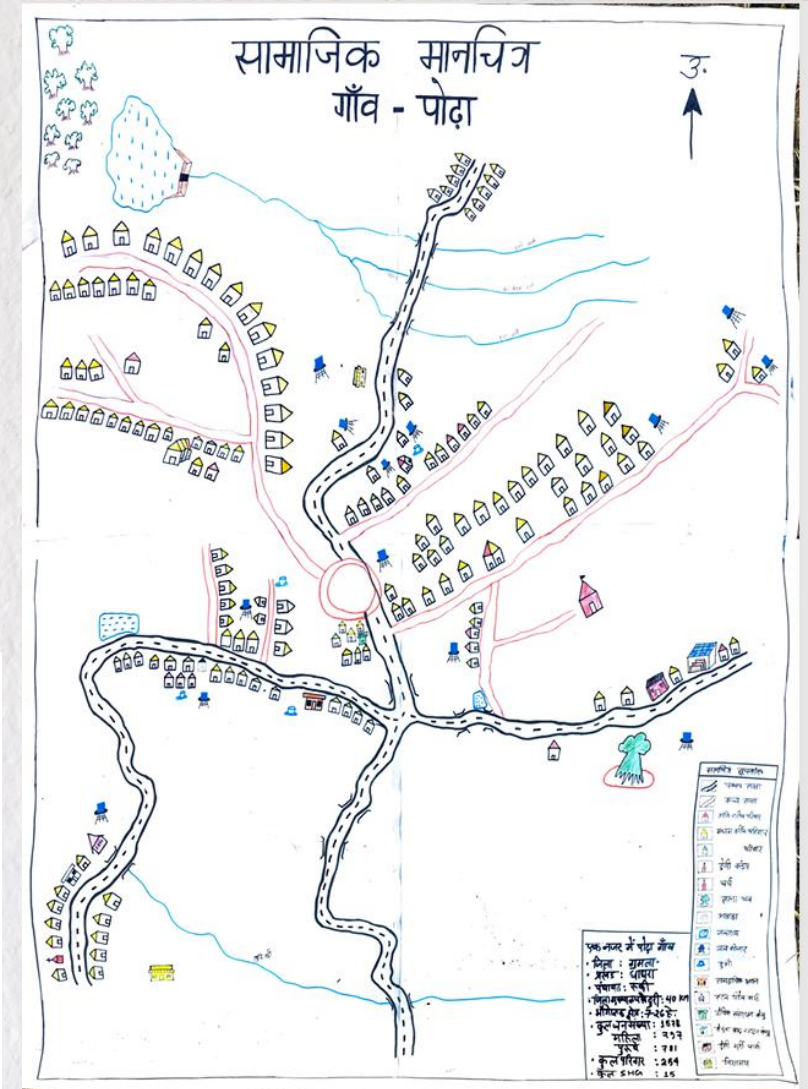
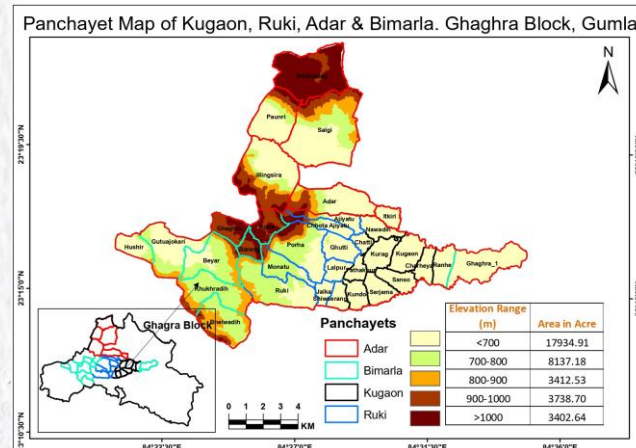
The Place – “This Is Our Village”

Podha is a small village among nine villages in Ruki Panchayat of Ghaghra block, located in Gumla district, Jharkhand. It lies 17 km from the block headquarters, 43 km from the district headquarters, and 117 km from Ranchi, the state capital.

The village consists of 254 families spread across three hamlets Podha, Basartoli, and Jawari with a total population of 1,578, including 781 males and 797 females. Children aged 0-6 years make up 19.89% (261) of the population. The sex ratio of 1,022 in Podha is notably higher than Jharkhand's state average of 948.

Podha is predominantly inhabited by Scheduled Tribes (ST), who constitute 87.20% of the population, while Scheduled Castes (SC) make up only 1.60%. The village is home to various communities, including the Oraon tribe, Chik Baraik, Lohra, Ahir, Munda tribe, and Yadav community.

The major languages spoken here are Sadri, Kurukh, and Hindi. The village follows a rich cultural tradition, with Sarna being the primary religion. However, there is also presence of Christianity and Hinduism. Traditional festivals such as Karma, Sarhul, and Nawakhani hold great importance, while over time, Holi, Durga Puja, and Diwali have also become widely celebrated due to cultural assimilation. Agriculture and livestock rearing are the primary sources of livelihood for the villagers.



The Place – “This Is Our Village”

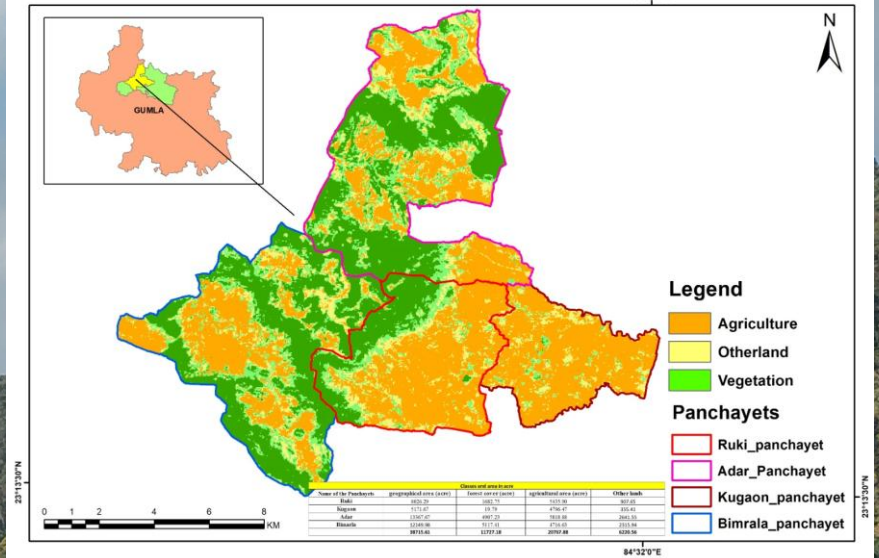
Resources and Livelihoods

Podha lies in a **forest-linked, rainfed agrarian landscape**, where agriculture, forests, and settlements exist in close proximity. Forests occupy a significant part of the surrounding area, while agricultural fields and settlements are mainly located in accessible low-lying and gently sloping terrain.

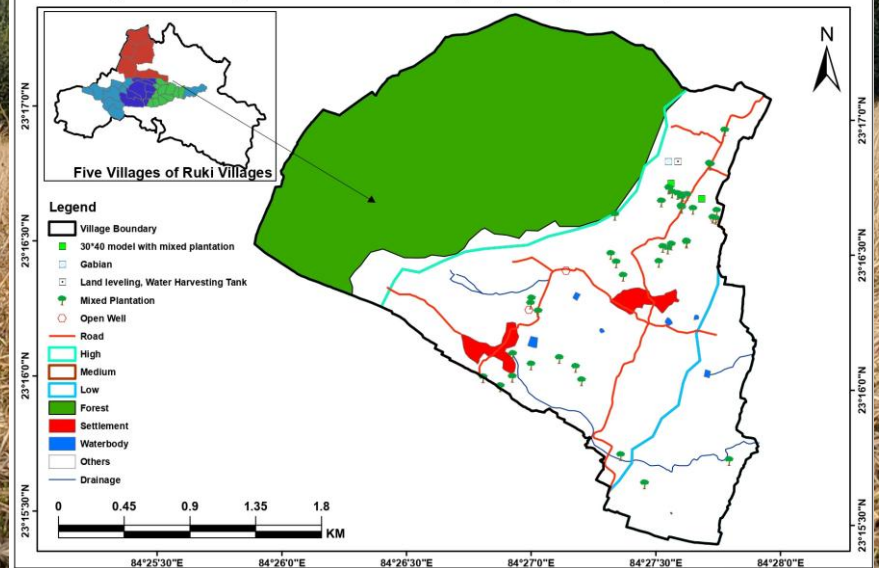
Agriculture is largely **rainfed**, with paddy as the main Kharif crop, followed by millets, pulses, vegetables, oilseeds, and limited horticulture. Water availability directly shapes crop choice, cropping intensity, and household livelihood decisions.

Livelihoods are diverse, with most households depending on a **combination of activities**. These include agriculture, livestock rearing—especially goats—collection of forest produce, and daily wage labour. Despite this diversity, **seasonal migration after the paddy harvest** remains common when local work is limited and cash needs rise.

Bioregion map covering the four panchayats, Ghagra Block



Bioregional Villages of Ruki Panchayet, Ghagra Block, Gumla District



The Place – “This Is Our Village”

Institutions

Podha has **15 active Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** and a **Village Organisation**, which together form the backbone of collective action in the village. SHGs support savings, credit, and problem-solving, and have enabled women to play a central role in discussions on agriculture, household expenses, and resource management.

Women’s collectives have emerged as key drivers of change, particularly in **regenerative agriculture** and **local enterprise initiatives**. Alongside this, the Village Organisation works to facilitate collective planning, strengthen participation in Gram Sabha processes, and address social and economic challenges.

Regular Gram Sabha meetings and village-level discussions have strengthened community ownership over development priorities, helping the village move from individual concerns to shared decision-making.

❖ The table below shows the SHGs of the village:

Village: Podha, Gram Panchayat: Ruki						
S. N.	SHG Name	Formation Date	Households			
			SC	ST	OBC	Total
1	Beli Mahila Mandal	01-06-2015		16	1	17
2	Bhagwati Mahila Mandal	08-06-2015		11	2	13
3	Chala Mahila Mandal	01-08-2008		20		20
4	Chameli Mahila Mandal	12-06-2012		12	2	14
5	Ganga Mahila Mandal	22-06-2015		10	5	15
6	Genda Mahila Mandal	12-06-2015		11		11
7	Bairangi Mahila Mandal	24-01-2014		20		20
8	Jamuna Mahila Mandal	20-06-2015		14	2	16
9	Jay Maa Saraswati Mahila Mandal	26-10-2014		15	5	20
10	Khushiya Mahila Mandal	05-04-2005	4	16		20
11	Santoshi Mahila Mandal	15-01-2014	5	15		20
12	Saraswati Mahila Mandal	18-04-2003		20		20
13	Sarna Mahila Mandal	18-04-2003		20		20
14	Sarai Phul Mahila Mandal	12-05-2023	2	12		14
15	Puja Mahila Mandal	19-06-2023	1	12		13
	TOTAL		12	224	17	253

Understanding Our Village – What We Studied Together

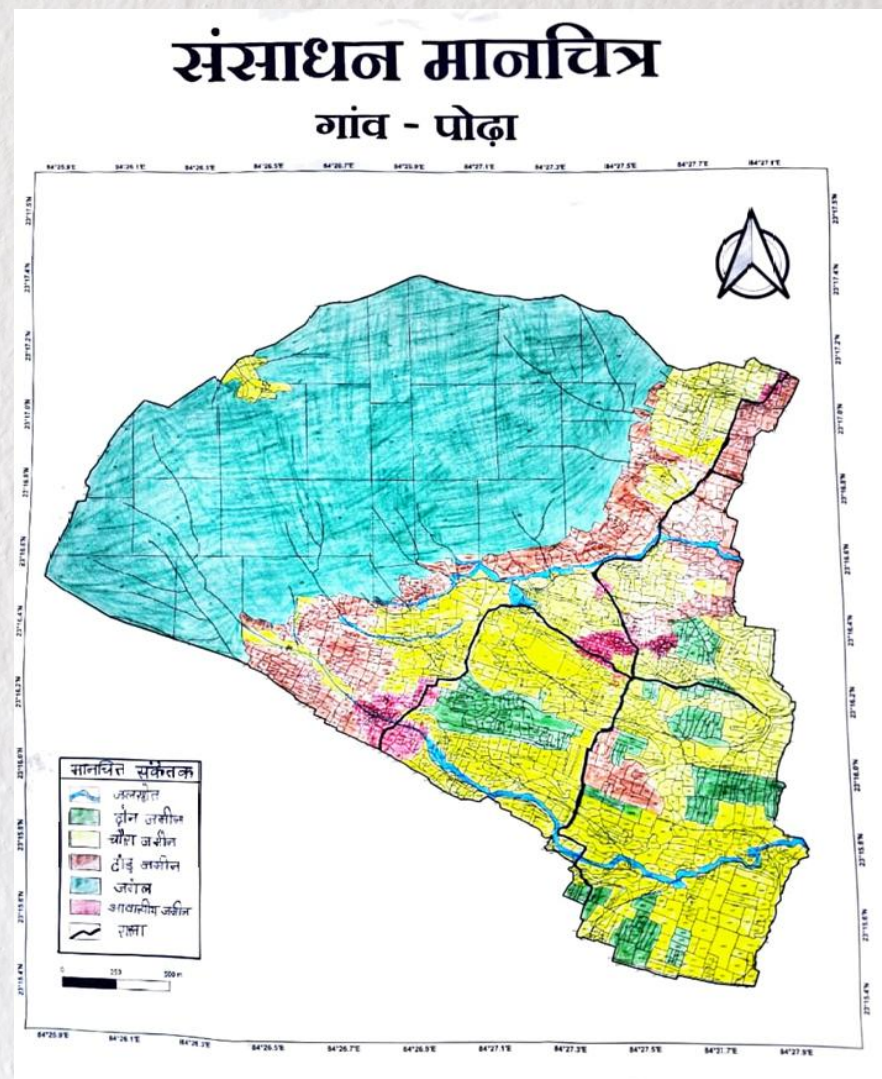
For Podha village, it began by **sitting together**—walking the land, drawing maps, talking about households, resources, and everyday expenses. This process allowed the village to look at itself not from outside, but from within.

The journey started with **collective meetings** where villagers discussed why it was important to understand their own village more deeply. This led to a series of participatory exercises that brought people together across hamlets, social groups, and economic categories. For many, this was the first time the village had paused to reflect collectively on how it functions as a whole.

Through **social mapping**, households were drawn on the ground and later on paper. Villagers marked institutions such as schools, Anganwadi centres, water points, roads, and places of worship. This exercise made visible both what exists and what is missing. It also helped the community recognise patterns of access and exclusion within the village.

The process of **wealth ranking** followed. Households were discussed openly and grouped based on locally understood indicators of well-being. This was not an easy exercise, but it helped the village acknowledge inequality and clearly identify ultra-poor households. More importantly, it shifted conversations from individual hardship to shared responsibility.

Alongside this, **resource mapping** focused attention on land, forests, water, livestock, and people. Using the 5J lens—*Jal, Jungle, Jamin, Janwar, Jan*—villagers discussed how resources are used, how they have changed over time, and how human actions affect ecological balance. These discussions revealed growing pressure on natural systems and declining returns from agriculture.



Understanding Our Village – What We Studied Together

As conversations deepened, the village moved towards **scorecard preparation**. Different aspects of social, economic, and ecological life were discussed and collectively rated. Villagers reflected on questions they had never asked together before:

- ☐ Which problems matter most?
- ☐ Where does money leave the village every day?
- ☐ Which changes are within our control?

This process created what many villagers described as a “**sense of disturbance**”—a realisation that while big expenses are noticed, small daily outflows and slow ecological decline often go unquestioned. At the same time, the exercise created clarity. Priorities became visible, and the village began to distinguish between immediate needs and long-term goals.

What made this process significant was not the tools themselves, but **how they were used**. Mapping, ranking, and scoring were not treated as one-time activities, but as spaces for dialogue. Village level discussions played a central role in validating findings and shaping next steps. Planning shifted from being externally driven to being **owned by the community**.

By the end of this collective inquiry, it had begun to see itself as a **connected system**—where land, forests, livelihoods, institutions, and everyday choices interact. This shared understanding laid the foundation for deciding priorities, experimenting with solutions, and imagining a different future.



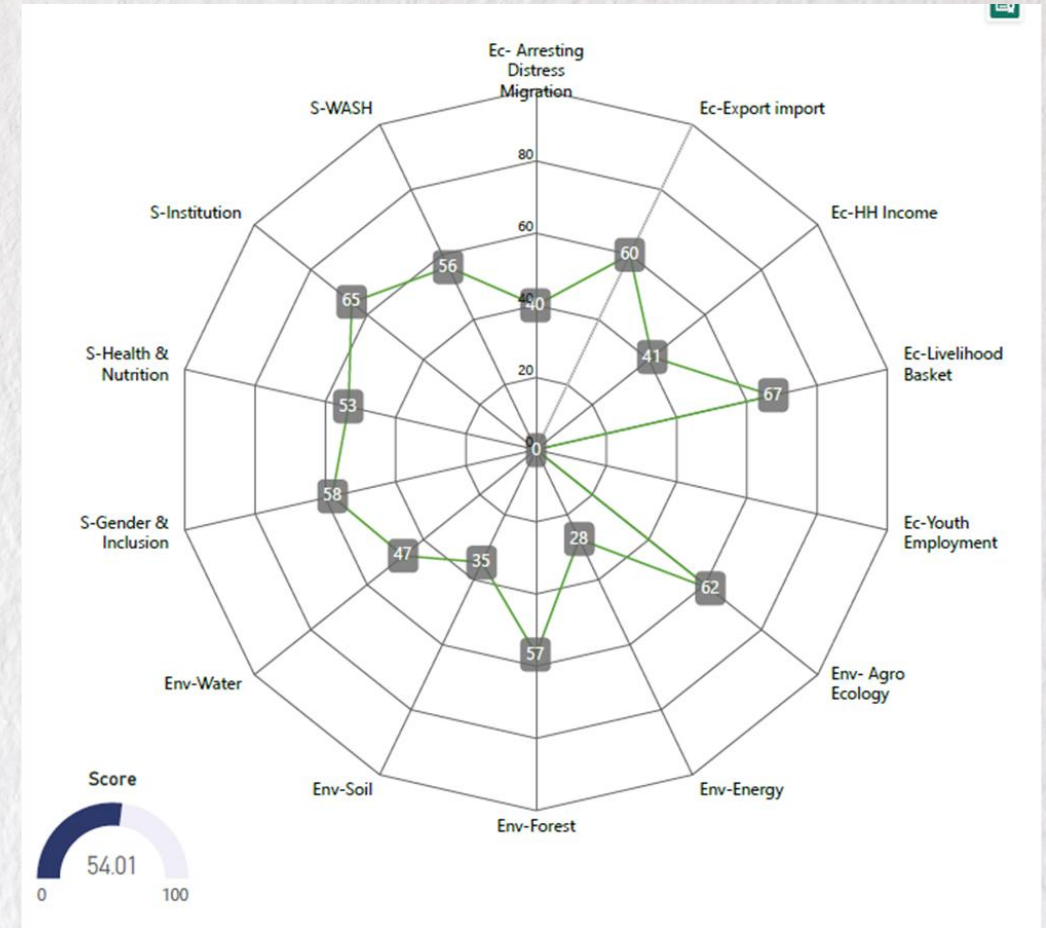
Understanding Our Village – What We Studied Together

Through the **Sense of the House exercise** and village scorecard, Podha began to see patterns that are usually hidden in everyday life. The learning came from **collective** reflection on economy, society, and ecology together.

The village realised that although exports and imports appear nearly balanced (about ₹2.1 Cr each), the economy is fragile. Exports depend heavily on **paddy**, while more than **half of imports are non-food essentials** such as fuel and household goods. As a result, much of the income entering the village quickly flows out, limiting local wealth creation.

Discussions on food and health showed that diets remain **cereal-dominated**. Protein-rich foods like eggs, fish, and chicken are mostly bought from outside, increasing expenses and nutritional risk. The village linked this to limited diversification in farming and livestock.

Gender discussions revealed a clear gap. While women are active in Self-Help Groups, their **access to land, assets, and economic decision-making** remains low due to customary practices and social norms.



Understanding Our Village – What We Studied Together

Ecological reflection highlighted the **forest–rainfall–water connection**. Declining forest health affects rainfall and groundwater recharge, leading to water stress, weaker agriculture, and greater pressure on forests—creating a reinforcing cycle.

The scorecard also showed that farming has become **input-intensive**, with high dependence on external seeds, fertilisers, and machinery, driven by limited irrigation and moderate soil fertility. This discourages diversification and increases risk.

High **distress migration** and low local youth employment further pointed to the absence of village-based enterprises and value addition around agriculture, livestock, and forest produce.

Together, these insights helped Podha see that economic, social, and ecological challenges are **interconnected**. Most importantly, the village gained clarity on *why* problems persist, creating a strong foundation for setting priorities and taking collective action.



Understanding Our Village – What We Studied Together

1. Strength lies in collective capability

Podha has realised that its true strength lies not only in land and forests, but in **shared knowledge, practices, and the ability to act together**. This shift has helped the village see itself as capable of shaping its own future.

2. Regenerative knowledge is now local

Farmers have adopted regenerative practices such as **Azolla, Daincha, vermicompost, and intercropping**, which are now viewed as locally owned solutions. These practices have reduced input costs, improved soil health, and restored confidence in farming. Nearly all households have experimented with them.

3. Livelihood skills are diversifying

Goat rearing has emerged as a reliable income source, with **₹1.3 lakh** in collective marketing. Alongside this, skills related to forest produce use and crop diversification show growing livelihood adaptability.

4. Women's collectives are driving change

Active **Self-Help Groups and the Village Organisation** have enabled women to move into leadership roles in agriculture, enterprise, and planning. Initiatives such as the **Bio Resource Centre and Rural Retail Mart** reflect this shift.

5. Collective decision-making is a core asset

Through mapping, scorecards, and Gram Sabha discussions, Podha has strengthened its ability to analyse itself, prioritise needs, and plan collectively. Early results—such as regenerative farming adoption, vermicompost production, forest regeneration efforts, and local enterprises—demonstrate that **change is possible**.



Community Plan in Brief

Social

- Regular Gram Sabha Meetings
- Restrict Cigarette Sales to Minors
- Alcohol Control through Alternate Livelihoods
- Establish Anganwadi Centre
- Strengthen Community School
- Improve Village Infrastructure
- Ultra poor Identification and Support

Ecology

- Paddy with Relay Crop – 180 HH
- Vegetable Cultivation – 150 HH
- Upland Mixed Cropping – 100 HH
- Multilayer Farming – 10 HH
- Intercropping in Orchard (Mango + Veg + Sunflower) – 20 Acre
- Intercropping with Horticulture – 50 HH
- Super Compost Preparation – 15 MT
- Livestock rearing and integrating with compost preparation
- CFR and IFR claim making
- 10K seedball every year
- Increased consumption of local food
- Vermicompost Preparation – 20 MT
- Gabion Structures – 2
- Land Labelling – 4 plots
- Loose Boulder Structures – 2
- Agro-horti– 60 HH
- 30x40 Moisture Structures – 3
- Well Construction – 3
- Water Harvesting Tank – 1
- Lac Cultivation – 40 HH
- Oil processing and use of good quality oil
- Establishment of small-scale enterprises **
- Mango processing
- Soap making
- Mud-Block unit
- Self-driven by the community
- Co-supported by Govt and PRADAN

** RRM,Huller,BRC,Compost unit, Soap production unit, Mango processing, Brood lac, Seed production

● Unmet needs

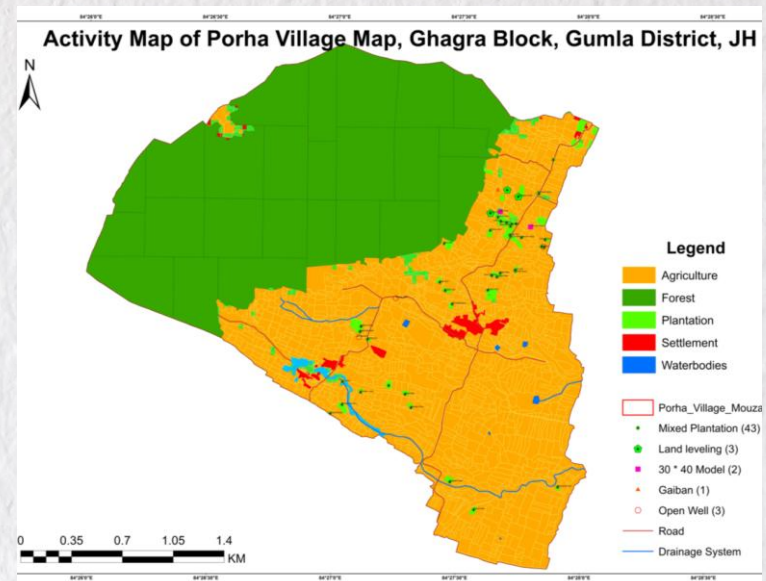
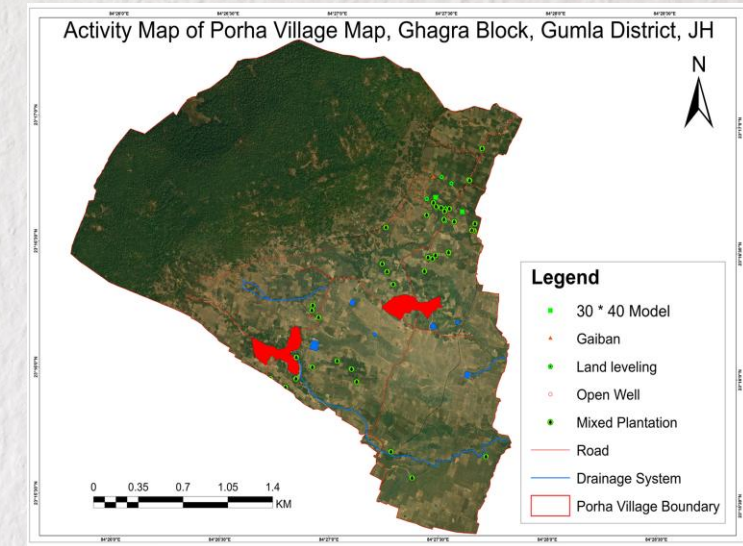


Glimpses of Progress

Land and Water Resources and collective efforts

PRADAN has been actively working in Podha to strengthen local institutions and CBOs. Efforts have focused on raising awareness among community members about their rights and entitlements, particularly within the Panchayati Raj system, emphasizing the power and role of the Gram Sabha. To enhance civic engagement, civic literacy modules were introduced, along with the identification of Left Out Poor to ensure inclusive development. Additionally, training on Gram Panchayat Development Planning was conducted, enabling the Gram Sabha to prepare its own development plan.

Under Integrated Natural Resource Management planning, the village has made significant progress, including the construction of two farm ponds and 27 new plantation orchards, which are currently underway. The Gram Sabha has submitted 29 plans this year to the department. Presently, Podha has two large ponds and over 65 wells, serving as crucial sources of irrigation and drinking water. Spanning 726 hectares, agricultural land constitutes 38% of the village's total area. The primary sources of irrigation include ponds, wells, and seasonal streams, which provide essential water supply for farming and daily use. These initiatives are contributing to a more resilient and self-sufficient community.



Forest Resources claim and management:

Forests are vital to Podha's livelihood and ecological balance, covering 329.04 hectares of land. Recognizing their importance, the village established a Forest Rights Committee in 2020, which led to the submission of Community Forest Rights claims under the Forest Rights Act, 2006. The community has taken proactive measures to conserve these forests, actively monitoring and controlling forest fires to safeguard natural resources. Over the past two years, villagers have collectively worked to restore degraded forest land through an innovative seed ball initiative. These seed balls, made from cow dung, soil, and seeds collected from the forest, help regenerate lost vegetation. In 2024, the community successfully planted 20,000 seed balls, further strengthening their commitment to forest conservation and sustainable land management. Their efforts highlight a harmonious relationship with nature, ensuring a greener and more resilient future.

The community is being trained in Community Forest Resource Management and has integrated it with INRM plans, ensuring sustainable forest conservation, water management, and agricultural resilience for long-term ecological balance.



Seed Ball Sowing

Journey towards sustainable and climate-resilient agriculture:

The journey toward regenerative farming in Podha began with just 12 farmers cultivating paddy. Today, this movement has expanded significantly, with around 210 households actively practicing regenerative agriculture across various models. This transformation has been driven by continuous training, easy access to inputs, exposure visits, and workshops, all of which have strengthened the confidence of both the community and the implementing team.

Farmers in Podha follow five key agricultural models:

1. Paddy with relay cropping
2. Mixed rainfed upland farming
3. Mixed vegetables cultivation
4. Trellis farming
5. Intercropping in Mango Orchard

A unique feature of Podha is its Bio-Resource Centre (BRC), which supplies biofertilizers and promotes sustainable farming Practices. Alongside the BRC, the village also has a Vermi compost unit, supported by IKEA Foundation, further supporting regenerative farming efforts. At present, the BRC is catering around 1000 families from the nearby villages. The BRC Entrepreneur also provides training and technical knowledge to the farmers around regenerative agriculture. Notably, 85% of households practice regenerative agriculture, enhancing soil health and productivity.



Azolla Application



Trellis Farming

Other Livelihoods and Linkage with Economic Institutions:

Agriculture and livestock rearing are the two primary sources of livelihood in Podha, with 80% of households engaged in agriculture. Goat rearing is another significant income-generating activity, with 115 households involved, many of whom have raised machans to improve livestock's health and hygiene. While fishing is practiced, it is primarily for household consumption rather than commercial purposes. With the support of PRADAN, Gram Sabha has identified 14 left out poor families in 2023, link them social entitlements, 6 of them are also linked with agriculture department through seed and fertilizers for practicing agriculture. 13 left out families are being linked with forest department for goat rearing activities. Ghaghra woman Farmer producer company is providing vet care and marketing services to all the households who are engaged in goat rearing activity. In addition to farming, villagers supplement their income through Non-Timber Forest Product (NTFP) collection and selling Karanj seeds, Mahua flowers, Sarai seeds, leafy vegetables, and Sal leaves. The village cultivates a diverse range of crops, including paddy, pulses such as red lentils, black gram, and pigeon peas, as well as mustard. Vegetable farming is also prominent, with crops like green peas, tomatoes, brinjals, onions, ginger, and garlic being widely grown. The nearest accessible market is in Adar, approximately 5 km away, serving as a key trading hub for the villagers. The village also boasts 35 acres of mango plantations, with farmers incorporating orchard farming techniques within these plots to optimize resource utilization and irrigation efficiency.



Our Future – The Village We Want to Build

Podha village, through collective reflection, has begun to imagine a future that is **economically secure, socially fair, and ecologically balanced**.

Podha envisions **affordable and regenerative farming**, with healthier soils, Synthetic chemical free farming, and shared responsibility for water and forests. Strengthening irrigation, restoring soil fertility, and regenerating forests are central to this vision.

The village also seeks to build **local livelihoods**, so that more value is created within the village and migration becomes a choice rather than a necessity. Small-scale processing, forest-based enterprises, livestock incomes, and local services are key to this aspiration.

Women and youth are central to this future. Women's collectives are expected to grow as decision-making institutions, while youth bring skills, technology, and enterprise ideas rooted in the village.

Above all, Podha's future is imagined as one that remains **rooted in land, culture, and values**, while adapting to change—building a village based on balance, self-reliance, and dignity.

